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# Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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# Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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## Chelsea's weakness is Arsenal's strength

Arsenal won the battle of set pieces, beating Chelsea 2-1 to keep [Manchester City](#) at bay. In a game that offered few clearcut chances from open play, it was a familiar story of Arsenal overpowering their opponents from corner kicks. Gabriel bullied Reece James to set up William Saliba for their first goal and Jurriën Timber punished a flailing Robert Sánchez for their second. Mikel Arteta's side have equalled the record for the most goals scored from corners in a Premier League season (16) with nine games still to go. Meanwhile, Chelsea have conceded seven goals from set pieces in Liam Rosenior's first 13 games in all competitions. Despite posing a threat offensively through Reece James's delivery for Piero Hincapié's own goal, they repeatedly failed to match Arsenal's physicality when defending. **Xaymaca Awoyungbo**

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Match report: [Arsenal 2-1 Chelsea](#)

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## Glasner is good, whatever he thinks

[After his claim last month](#) that he was "just not good enough" to be Crystal Palace manager, Oliver Glasner has shown the polar opposite. His team won their next two games – against Wolves and Zrinjski Mostar – and while they lost 2-1 at Manchester United on Sunday, the Eagles took the lead at Old Trafford and might have ended with the victory but for the double-whammy of Maxence Lacroix picking up a red card and conceding the penalty that provided Bruno Fernandes' leveller. The Austrian is enthused, too. "Absolutely. The performances were not that bad," he said. "The way the team is fighting, even here under difficult circumstances, gives me faith until the end of the season." Palace's decision not to sack Glasner after his outburst now seems wise. **Jamie Jackson**

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Match report: [Manchester United 2-1 Crystal Palace](#)

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## Gray unfairly at risk of Jonah status

Poor Archie Gray. In the season he turned 17 he was an unused substitute six times as Leeds were relegated. Now, at the ripe old age of 19, he's a regular starter in a Tottenham side that, unthinkably, find themselves in serious danger of the drop. He risks becoming a Jonah figure before he's old enough to get an HGV licence. Yet none of this is his fault. Rather Gray's remarkable versatility means he's always the player shuffled around. He's a holding midfielder, but he's been regularly deployed at centre-back for Tottenham. Last week against [Arsenal](#) he was used as a right-wingback, and at Fulham he was at left-back. It was his surge forward and cross with his supposedly weaker foot that brought the Tottenham goal. Perhaps adversity will toughen him, but the fear is that the failure of others drags him down. **Jonathan Wilson**

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*Match report:* [Fulham 2-1 Tottenham](#)

## Pickford basks in denying Newcastle

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As a disconsolate Eddie Howe began his post-match interviews, the jubilant chants of departing Everton fans on the concourses outside penetrated the inner walls of St James' Park. "He's a Mackem, he's a Blue. He's a Toffee through and through. He hates Newcastle, he hates the Shite [Liverpool], Jordan Pickford's dynamite," they chorused as David Moyes and his players celebrated the 3-2 win that consigned Newcastle to a particularly chastening defeat. Without Pickford, though, it would have ended 3-3. When Sandro Tonali struck a perfect, thunderous volley in stoppage time an equaliser seemed inevitable. Or at least it did until Pickford somehow tipped the ball over the bar. "It felt good," said the lifelong [Sunderland](#) supporter, who began his career at the Stadium of Light and is routinely baited by Newcastle fans. "Tonali's hit an absolute rocket, he's caught it really sweet. I think it's my best save ever." In marked contrast Nick Pope's hopes of joining Pickford in England's World Cup squad were surely dented by the error that permitted Beto to score Everton's second goal. **Louise Taylor**

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*Match report:* [Newcastle 2-3 Everton](#)

## Semenyo savouring winning mentality

Antoine Semenyo was the match-winner at Leeds, making up for Erling Haaland's absence as Manchester City continued to keep the pressure on Arsenal. It was not a vintage performance from Pep Guardiola's side but it offered evidence of grit and determination. Semenyo was alert when a rare chance arrived to maintain his fine run since joining from [Bournemouth](#). "I feel like in the month and a bit that I've been here, my mentality has shifted," Semenyo said. "It's just win, win, win, win, win. And when we are winning, defend like our lives depend on it." He has scored six goals for his new club already and is an important component in the battle for the title. "I felt like I just want to contribute the best way I can. So if I am scoring goals, great," Semenyo said. "I think there's bigger things that we're looking to achieve as a team, and obviously as individuals, but we just want that title. That's the most important thing for me." **Will Unwin**

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*Match report:* [Leeds 0-1 Manchester City](#)

## Damsgaard's wild bookends

A lot happened between Mikkel Damsgaard's two goals at Turf Moor. To be specific: 86 minutes, five goals and what Burnley thought was a completed comeback from three down. The opener of [this seven-goal thriller](#) was as unlikely as the events that followed as Damsgaard, not the biggest physical presence, headed in Dango Ouattara's corner. The Brentford midfielder was then in his more usual position as chief creator, sliding a pass in behind for Igor Thiago to double their lead. After Zian Flemming thought he had not only hauled Burnley level but put them 4-3 up in the second half – only for his second to be disallowed for offside – Damsgaard put Brentford back in front as he touched down Rico Henry's cross and drilled into the far corner in stoppage time. The Denmark international, a consistent performer as a No 10 in Keith Andrews' system, had not scored for his club since September. This will probably make up for it. Burnley's Ashley Barnes, aged 36, has not scored in the Premier League for almost four years. After his even-later equaliser was scrubbed off by the video assistant referee, that wait goes on. **Billy Munday**

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*Match report:* [Burnley 3-4 Brentford](#)

## Reds turn corner on set-piece goals

Liverpool's transformation into set-piece specialists was long overdue for Arne Slot, and fundamental to victory against West Ham, although the head coach was reluctant to go into detail on the reasons for it. "Things went back to normal," was his explanation for how a team that had scored the fewest set-piece goals in the [Premier League](#) by 1 January (three) have converted more than any other since (nine). The response appeared a courtesy to Aaron Briggs, the former set-piece coach who left Liverpool in December, and recognition that the team are now outperforming their expected goals, both in terms of scoring and defending set pieces, having underperformed at both in the first half of the season. Since Briggs's departure the set-piece analyst Lewis Mahoney has taken on more responsibility and Liverpool have delivered more inswinging corners towards the six-yard box this year. The results are striking – on Saturday Liverpool became the first team to score three goals from corners in the first half of a Premier League game for 10 years – and will be key to the pursuit of Champions League qualification. **Andy Hunter**

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## Evergreen Welbeck joins Vardy club

Danny Welbeck's winning goal against [Nottingham Forest](#) means he has joined an exclusive club. The Brighton striker took his season's tally in the Premier League to 10, to match his previous best from last year and became the first player since Jamie Vardy to reach double figures while aged 33 or older. Welbeck's clinical finish against Forest showed all the nous he has accumulated in almost two decades in the top flight as he held off his marker before unleashing an unstoppable shot. Fabian Hürzeler believes the 35-year-old is in the best condition since his arrival as head coach on the south coast in 2024. "It's how he behaves as a professional, how he's there for the team on and off the pitch," he said. "He seems to be in his best shape ever, and therefore for me it's no coincidence. He always tries to push himself." **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Brighton 2-1 Nottingham Forest](#)

## Hill typifies Bournemouth's cherrypicking

Bournemouth lost an entire defence and a goalkeeper last summer but are one of the hardest teams to beat in this season's Premier League. Andoni Iraola regularly laments an inability to finish off opponents, with a division-leading 12 draws, though [only Arsenal](#) have beaten Bournemouth in 2026. The club's unearthing of talent, trusting players from the Football League, continues to bear fruit. James Hill began his career at Fleetwood, waiting his turn. "It's taken a while for me to actually build a run of games together, but I've worked hard," said the centre-back who arrived in 2022 but is seizing the opportunity to strike up a partnership with Marcos Senesi, Adrien Truffert and Álex Jiménez, and Djordje Petrovic in goal. "At the start of the season, I couldn't even make the squad," he said after Saturday's bruising battle with Sunderland's forwards. Hill boasts an impressive long throw, increasing his importance to Iraola's much-admired and resilient team. **John Brewin**

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*Match report:* [Bournemouth 1-1 Sunderland](#)

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## Agitated Emery needs swift riposte

On the same evening that unfounded conspiracies raged that Jim Carrey sent a clone to film awards in Paris, it was tempting to wonder whether Unai Emery had played a similar trick at Molineux. The Villa manager grew increasingly agitated during his side's 2-0 defeat and headed down the tunnel as Wolves savoured their second goal but afterwards he was at pains to be upbeat, calling for perspective as he talked of how only five months ago he was fretting about relegation. Now the biggest fear is missing out on the Champions League. Emery insisted he had parked his disappointment as Villa extended their miserable run to three wins in 10 league matches, a shock loss heightening the importance of Wednesday's date with [Chelsea](#) at Villa Park. "I am motivated and so, so excited with the objectives we have in front of us," Emery said. "On Wednesday, Chelsea. What a match. On game 29, we are going to play in front of them in the table." **Ben Fisher**

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*Match report:* [Wolves 2-0 Aston Villa](#)

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| Pos | Team              | P  | GD  | Pts |
|-----|-------------------|----|-----|-----|
| 1   | Arsenal           | 29 | 36  | 64  |
| 2   | Man City          | 28 | 32  | 59  |
| 3   | Man Utd           | 28 | 12  | 51  |
| 4   | Aston Villa       | 28 | 8   | 51  |
| 5   | Liverpool         | 28 | 10  | 48  |
| 6   | Chelsea           | 28 | 16  | 45  |
| 7   | Brentford         | 28 | 4   | 43  |
| 8   | Everton           | 28 | -1  | 40  |
| 9   | Fulham            | 28 | -2  | 40  |
| 10  | AFC Bournemouth   | 28 | -2  | 39  |
| 11  | Brighton          | 28 | 3   | 37  |
| 12  | Sunderland        | 28 | -5  | 37  |
| 13  | Newcastle         | 28 | -2  | 36  |
| 14  | Crystal Palace    | 28 | -4  | 35  |
| 15  | Leeds             | 28 | -10 | 31  |
| 16  | Tottenham Hotspur | 28 | -5  | 29  |
| 17  | Nottm Forest      | 28 | -15 | 27  |
| 18  | West Ham          | 28 | -20 | 25  |
| 19  | Burnley           | 28 | -24 | 19  |
| 20  | Wolverhampton     | 29 | -31 | 13  |



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